The Superiority of the Promise to the Law

The law, arriving 430 years later, cannot annul or add to God's unconditional promise to Abraham. It was temporary, needed a mediator, and served to drive sinners to Christ — while the promise makes believers sons and heirs forever.

Source: Dr. C. Norman Sellers, ThD · SellersBibleInstitute.com · used by permission

Where this study fits

Galatians · sixteen studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–5 The Ground of Liberty	**02** 1:6–10 The One True Gospel	**03** 1:11–17 Paul's Independent Revelation	**04** 1:18–2:10 Paul's Gospel Is Independent of the Judean Churches
05 2:11–21 Peter Goes Back to School	**06** 3:1–5 Under a Spell	**07** 3:6–14 Blessing or a Curse	**08** 3:15–29 The Superiority of the Promise to the Law
09 4:1–11 When I Became a Man	**10** 4:12–20 A Steel Fist in a Velvet Glove	**11** 4:21–31 Paul's Old Testament Story	**12** 5:1–12 Taking a Stand in Liberty
13 5:13–26 Walk in the Spirit	**14** 6:1–5 Brothers and Burdens	**15** 6:6–10 Sowing and Reaping	**16** 6:11–18 Teaching the Truth

The promise and the law: four comparisons

Galatians 3:15–29 · The commentary's outline

I Not part of the promise

3:15–18 — a confirmed covenant can't be annulled or added to

II Not on a par with it

3:19–20 — added for transgressions, temporary, needed a mediator

III A purpose in the promise

3:21–25 — exposed weakness and sin, and drove us to Christ

IV Inferior prospects

3:26–29 — sons, clothed with Christ, one in Christ, heirs

The law was holy and good — it did its job, and now it is gone. Salvation is by grace through faith, plus not one thing.

A covenant only God could keep

Galatians 3:15–16 · Genesis 12 and 15 · Outline I.A–B

God told him	Abraham asked	Abraham slept	God alone passed
“I will bless you…” — no requirements placed on Abraham	“How shall I know?” — animals laid out as for a covenant	A deep sleep fell on him — he could not be a party	A smoking furnace and a burning lamp passed between the pieces
Gen 12:3	*Gen 15:8–10*	*Gen 15:12*	*Gen 15:17*

A covenant — v.15
διαθήκη a will; once confirmed, unalterable

- No one annuls or adds to it but its makers

The Seed — v.16
σπέρμα singular

- “and to your Seed,” who is Christ

Three unconditional promises to Abraham

Galatians 3:16–18 · Outline I.B–C

1	**Land** Expanded in the Palestinian Covenant	**Deut 29–30**
2	**Nation** Expanded in the Davidic Covenant	**2 Samuel 7**
3	**Blessing** Ultimately the New Covenant	**Jer 31 · Heb 8**

The law came too late — v.17
430 years

- Cannot annul a covenant “confirmed before by God”

The law contradicts the promise — v.18

- If the inheritance is of the law, it is no longer of promise
- Promise and law cannot be mixed

Law and promise side by side

Galatians 3:17–20 · Outline II — Not on a par with the promise

	The Law	The Promise
Arrived	430 years after the promise	First — confirmed beforehand by God
Came because of	Transgressions — disobedience (παράβασις)	Obedience — Abraham believed God
Duration	Temporary — “till the Seed should come”	Permanent
Parties	Two — needed a mediator, Moses (μεσίτης)	One — “God is one”; no mediator
Terms	Conditional: do this and live	Unconditional: God alone bound Himself

What the law was for

Galatians 3:21–25 · Outline III — The law had a purpose

A Demonstrate weakness

μὴ γένοιτο
v.21 — no law could give life; “Certainly not!”

B Display sinfulness

συνέκλεισεν
v.22 — Scripture shut up all under sin (Rom 3:9, 23)

C Drive to Christ

παιδαγωγός
vv.23–25 — the slave-escort until faith came; now no longer under him

You can't be saved until you know you need to be saved. The law showed the need; Christ meets it.

What the promise gives that the law never could

Galatians 3:26–29 · Outline IV — Higher, deeper, wider, longer

↑ **Higher · v.26**

υἱοί θεοῦ
Sons of God through faith in Christ Jesus

↓ **Deeper · v.27**

ἐνεδύσασθε
Baptized by the Spirit into Christ — clothed with Him (1 Cor 12:13)

↔ **Wider · v.28**

Neither Jew nor Greek, slave nor free, male nor female — all one in Christ

∞ **Longer · v.29**

κληρονόμοι
Abraham's seed and heirs according to the promise — forever

Discuss and apply

Galatians 3:15–29 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. What does it mean that Abraham was asleep while God alone passed through the pieces (Genesis 15)?

2. Of the four ways our standing surpasses the law — higher, deeper, wider, longer — which means most to you right now, and why?

Apply

Rest in “You Have Been Blessed, Do This”
Before you pray tonight, say aloud “I have already been blessed” before anything you plan to do for God.

Live the Wide Ground
Extend a specific honor this week to a believer you might ordinarily overlook.

In one line: The promise came first and stands forever; the law's work was to lead us to Christ.